

Name: _____

Date: _____

The Storm at Heron's Rest

Year 5 reading comprehension · Story · 14 marks · About 25 minutes

By the time Ellis reached the harbour wall, the sky had turned the colour of old slate. Out at sea, the waves were growing taller, and the wind had begun to howl through the rigging of the small boats. Ellis pulled his hood tight and pushed on towards the lighthouse.

Heron's Rest had been home to the Penhallow family for four generations. Ellis's great-grandfather had kept the lamp burning through storms long before electricity reached the coast, and Ellis's mother still checked the light each evening. Tonight, though, she was away at the mainland hospital, and the keys were in Ellis's pocket.

He climbed the winding stairs two at a time, his breath ragged. At the top, the great lamp sat dark and silent. Ellis fumbled with the switch. Nothing. He tried again, and a faint crackle of static was the only reply.

Through the glass he could see a single fishing boat battling the swell, its tiny lantern flickering like a dying star. Somebody out there was relying on this light, and the only person who could help was a twelve-year-old with cold hands and a pounding heart.

Ellis took a deep breath. He remembered the old brass lantern that his mother kept in the cupboard beneath the stairs, "for emergencies only". He raced down, wrenched open the door and found it wrapped in a blanket, its glass polished and its oil topped up.

Back at the top, his hands shook as he struck the match. The flame caught, steadied and grew. Ellis lifted the lantern high in the window and began to swing it in slow, deliberate arcs, just as he had seen his mother do on the night of the last big storm.

Out on the water, the little boat turned slowly towards the safety of the harbour.

1. For how many generations had the Penhallow family lived at Heron's Rest? (1 mark)

2. Why was Ellis alone at the lighthouse that evening? (1 mark)

3. Find and copy one word from the third paragraph that tells you the stairs were not straight. (1 mark)

4. How can you tell that Ellis was nervous as he climbed to the lamp room and lit the lantern? Give two pieces of evidence from the story. (2 marks)

5. The author describes the boat's lantern as "flickering like a dying star". What does this comparison suggest about the boat's situation? (2 marks)

6. Why do you think Ellis's mother kept the brass lantern "for emergencies only"? (2 marks)

7. Summarise the story in no more than three sentences. Say what the problem was, what Ellis did and what happened in the end. (3 marks)

8. How do you think Ellis's mother will feel when she hears what he did? Use evidence from the story to explain your answer. (2 marks)

Writing task: Write the next scene. Ellis's mother comes home. What does she say, and what does Ellis tell her?
